

Neural Warm-Up Protocol

Soccer / Fútbol – Pre-Game (5–7 minutes)

Purpose:

Prepare the brain, eyes, and nervous system to see the game sooner, decide faster, and execute with control under pressure.

1. Breathing Reset (Eyes Open)

Time: ~1 minute

- Inhale through the nose for **4 seconds**
- Exhale slowly through the mouth for **8 seconds**
- Repeat **4 cycles**
- Keep **eyes open**
- Stand tall, shoulders relaxed, jaw loose

Goal:

Calm the nervous system while maintaining alert vision and awareness.

2. Horizontal Saccades (Thumb Targets)

Reps: 20 total

- Hold both thumbs out in front of you at shoulder width
- Keep head still
- Move eyes **left to right** quickly between thumbs

- Stay fast but accurate

Goal:

Prime rapid scanning and visual shifts used for passing lanes and opponent tracking.

3. Vertical Saccades (Thumb Targets)

Reps: 20 total

- Hold one thumb higher and one lower in front of you
- Keep head still
- Move eyes **up and down** quickly between thumbs
- Maintain control and clarity

Goal:

Prepare vision for aerial balls, vertical space changes, and field awareness.

4. VOR – Side to Side

Reps: 10

- Hold one thumb at arm's length in front of you
- Lock eyes on the thumb
- Turn head **side to side**
- Thumb must stay **clear, not blurry**

Goal:

Stabilize vision during running, cutting, and rapid head movement.

5. VOR – Up and Down

Reps: 10

- Hold thumb at arm's length
- Lock eyes on the thumb
- Move head **up and down**
- Keep thumb clear the entire time

Goal:

Maintain visual clarity during jumps, headers, and vertical motion.

6. Peripheral Hand Motion Copy Drill (Partner-Based)

Reps: 10 random patterns

- Athlete and teammate stand facing each other
- Athlete **locks eyes on the teammate's nose** and does not move eyes
- Teammate creates **random hand movement patterns** using **both hands**
- Athlete uses **peripheral vision only** to see the pattern
- Athlete **copies the hand pattern** simultaneously
- Eyes remain locked on the nose the entire time

Goal:

Train peripheral awareness, pattern recognition, and motor response without losing central focus.

When to Use

- Before team warm-ups
 - Right before kickoff
 - At halftime if focus drops
 - Before penalties or high-pressure moments
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Key Reminder for Athletes

You are not trying to get tired.

You are training your **eyes, brain, and nervous system** to be ready before the game starts.

Elite Athlete Next Step

If you are an **elite player** and want to level up your **visual and cognitive skills**, **scan here** for a **quick chat with Dr. Shah** to discuss the **12-week program** designed to do exactly that — including **weekly virtual visits and virtual testing**.



Don't forget to **tag** us when you do your warmups!!

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